

COMPLETE CHESS LEARNING LIBRARY

The Complete Rook Endgame Course

Lucena, Philidor, activity, checking distance, transitions, and practical technique

COURSE BOOK

20 focused chapters - model positions - decision rules - retrieval practice

Designed to change what you notice, calculate, remember, and do at the board.

How to Use This Course

ONE CHAPTER, FOUR PASSES

1. Read the position without moving pieces. 2. State your plan and the opponent's counterplay. 3. Study the decision rules. 4. Close the book and reconstruct the position from memory.

RETRIEVAL SCHEDULE

Review the chapter the next day, one week later, and after a game that reaches a similar structure. Retrieval is more valuable than rereading.

BOARD ROUTINE

Opponent's threat - forcing moves - loose pieces - worst piece - central break - best reply - choose and stop.

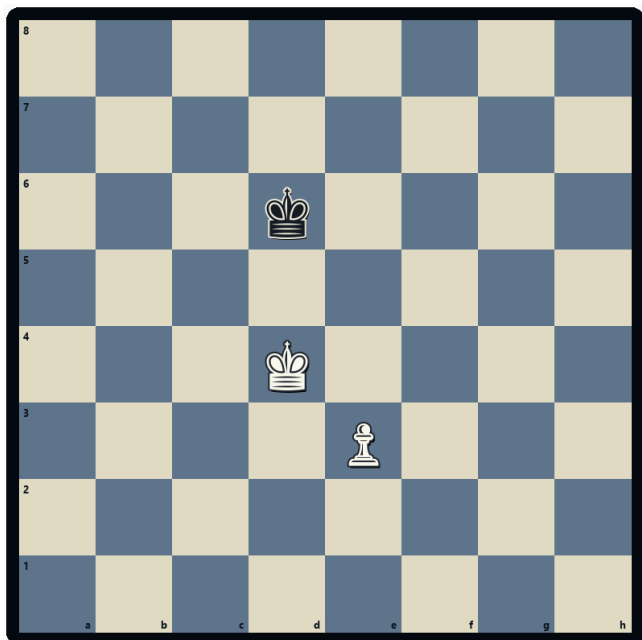
The course book explains each model position. The separate workbook forces recall, prediction, and self-scoring. Use the book first, then attempt the matching workbook page without looking back.

Engine evaluations are intentionally not the lesson. The aim is to store human decision rules that remain useful when the exact move order changes.

Course Map

MODULE	CHAPTERS
ROOK ENDGAMES	20

01. Rook Activity Before Pawns



ROOK ENDGAMES

READ THE POSITION

Activate the rook before collecting pawns; an active rook can compensate for material.

PRIMARY PLAN

Identify the defender's best resource, map both king routes, and choose the move that preserves activity or the winning mechanism.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

The opponent seeks checks, king access, liquidation, a fortress, or a pawn race that changes the evaluation.

REFERENCE LINE

White to move - opposition study

MEMORY RULE

Activate the rook before collecting pawns; an active rook can compensate for material.

01. Decision Framework

Rook Activity Before Pawns

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Calculate every forcing check, capture, pawn advance, and promotion tempo until the position becomes stable.
PIECE JOB	Place the king first, then position the rook or minor piece where it restricts the enemy king and supports the passer.
TACTICAL WARNING	Watch skewers, forks, rook sacrifices for the last pawn, promotion with check, and stalemate resources.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after proving the resulting pawn ending or theoretical position.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Reconstruct the position from memory and state the winning or drawing mechanism without moving pieces.
CLOCK RULE	Use known theoretical landmarks to save time, then calculate the concrete exception.

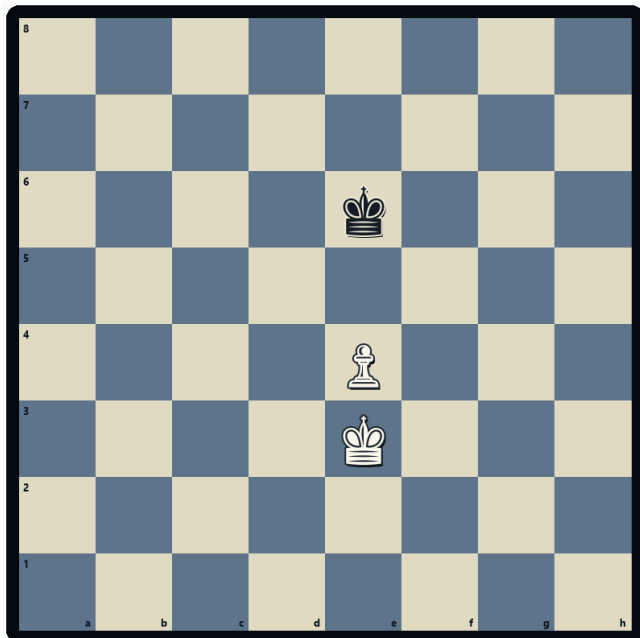
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Activate the rook before collecting pawns; an active rook can compensate for material.

02. Rook Behind the Passed Pawn



ROOK ENDGAMES

READ THE POSITION

Place the rook behind a passed pawn, whether the pawn is yours or the opponent's.

PRIMARY PLAN

Identify the defender's best resource, map both king routes, and choose the move that preserves activity or the winning mechanism.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

The opponent seeks checks, king access, liquidation, a fortress, or a pawn race that changes the evaluation.

REFERENCE LINE

White to move - key-square study

MEMORY RULE

Place the rook behind a passed pawn, whether the pawn is yours or the opponent's.

02. Decision Framework

Rook Behind the Passed Pawn

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Calculate every forcing check, capture, pawn advance, and promotion tempo until the position becomes stable.
PIECE JOB	Place the king first, then position the rook or minor piece where it restricts the enemy king and supports the passer.
TACTICAL WARNING	Watch skewers, forks, rook sacrifices for the last pawn, promotion with check, and stalemate resources.
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ENDGAME FORECAST	Reconstruct the position from memory and state the winning or drawing mechanism without moving pieces.
CLOCK RULE	Use known theoretical landmarks to save time, then calculate the concrete exception.

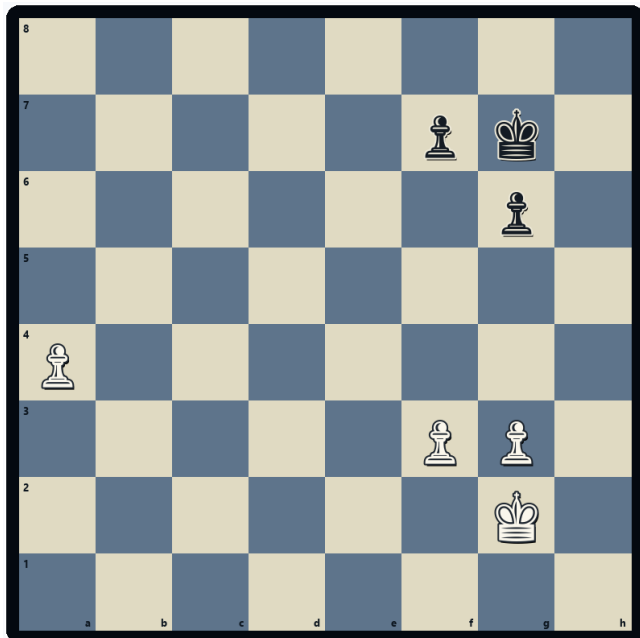
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Place the rook behind a passed pawn, whether the pawn is yours or the opponent's.

03. Lucena Bridge Building



ROOK ENDGAMES

READ THE POSITION

Cut off the enemy king and use the rook as a shield to promote.

PRIMARY PLAN

Identify the defender's best resource, map both king routes, and choose the move that preserves activity or the winning mechanism.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

The opponent seeks checks, king access, liquidation, a fortress, or a pawn race that changes the evaluation.

REFERENCE LINE

White to move - create a diversion

MEMORY RULE

Cut off the enemy king and use the rook as a shield to promote.

03. Decision Framework

Lucena Bridge Building

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Calculate every forcing check, capture, pawn advance, and promotion tempo until the position becomes stable.
PIECE JOB	Place the king first, then position the rook or minor piece where it restricts the enemy king and supports the passer.
TACTICAL WARNING	Watch skewers, forks, rook sacrifices for the last pawn, promotion with check, and stalemate resources.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after proving the resulting pawn ending or theoretical position.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Reconstruct the position from memory and state the winning or drawing mechanism without moving pieces.
CLOCK RULE	Use known theoretical landmarks to save time, then calculate the concrete exception.

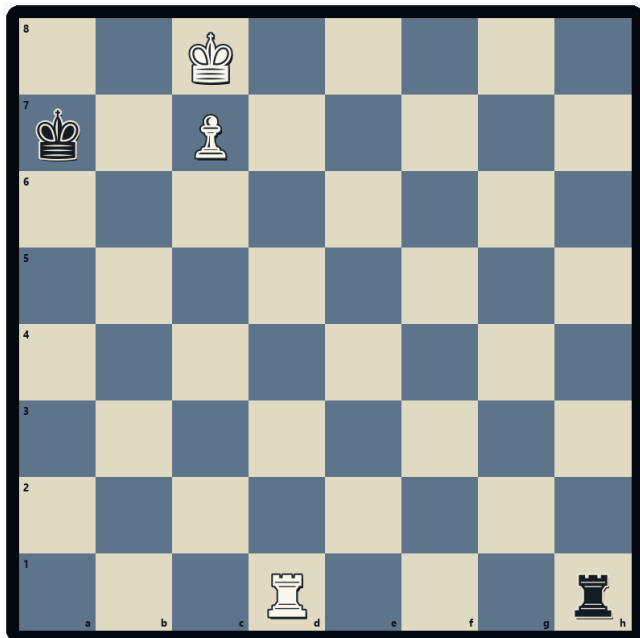
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Cut off the enemy king and use the rook as a shield to promote.

04. Philidor Third-Rank Defense



ROOK ENDGAMES

READ THE POSITION

Keep the king in front, hold the third rank, and check from behind when the pawn advances.

PRIMARY PLAN

Identify the defender's best resource, map both king routes, and choose the move that preserves activity or the winning mechanism.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

The opponent seeks checks, king access, liquidation, a fortress, or a pawn race that changes the evaluation.

REFERENCE LINE

White to move - Lucena-type position

MEMORY RULE

Keep the king in front, hold the third rank, and check from behind when the pawn advances.

04. Decision Framework

Philidor Third-Rank Defense

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Calculate every forcing check, capture, pawn advance, and promotion tempo until the position becomes stable.
PIECE JOB	Place the king first, then position the rook or minor piece where it restricts the enemy king and supports the passer.
TACTICAL WARNING	Watch skewers, forks, rook sacrifices for the last pawn, promotion with check, and stalemate resources.
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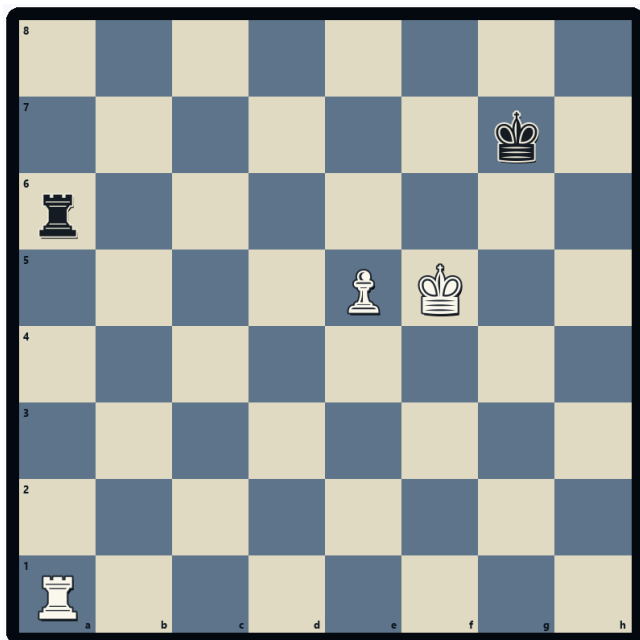
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Keep the king in front, hold the third rank, and check from behind when the pawn advances.

05. Cutting Off the King



ROOK ENDGAMES

READ THE POSITION

One file of separation can decide whether the defender reaches the promotion square.

PRIMARY PLAN

Identify the defender's best resource, map both king routes, and choose the move that preserves activity or the winning mechanism.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

The opponent seeks checks, king access, liquidation, a fortress, or a pawn race that changes the evaluation.

REFERENCE LINE

Black to move - Philidor-type defense

MEMORY RULE

One file of separation can decide whether the defender reaches the promotion square.

05. Decision Framework

Cutting Off the King

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Calculate every forcing check, capture, pawn advance, and promotion tempo until the position becomes stable.
PIECE JOB	Place the king first, then position the rook or minor piece where it restricts the enemy king and supports the passer.
TACTICAL WARNING	Watch skewers, forks, rook sacrifices for the last pawn, promotion with check, and stalemate resources.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after proving the resulting pawn ending or theoretical position.
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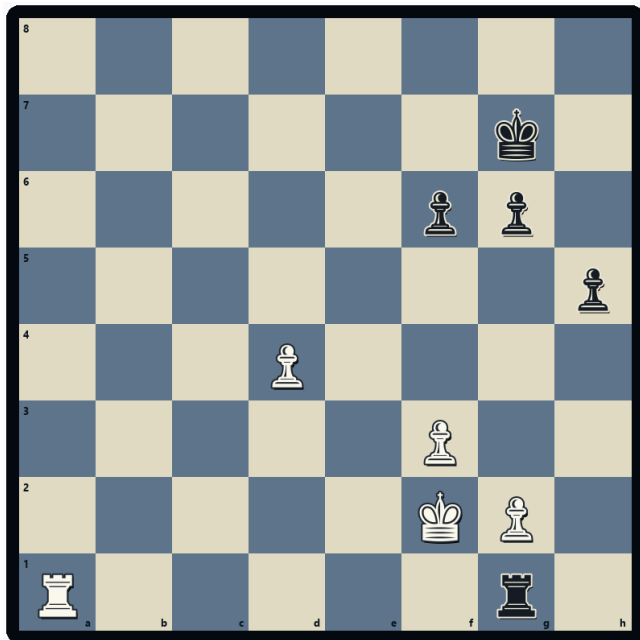
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1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: One file of separation can decide whether the defender reaches the promotion square.

06. Checking Distance



ROOK ENDGAMES

READ THE POSITION

Give checks from far enough away that the king cannot attack the rook with tempo.

PRIMARY PLAN

Identify the defender's best resource, map both king routes, and choose the move that preserves activity or the winning mechanism.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

The opponent seeks checks, king access, liquidation, a fortress, or a pawn race that changes the evaluation.

REFERENCE LINE

White to move - activity over passivity

MEMORY RULE

Give checks from far enough away that the king cannot attack the rook with tempo.

06. Decision Framework

Checking Distance

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Calculate every forcing check, capture, pawn advance, and promotion tempo until the position becomes stable.
PIECE JOB	Place the king first, then position the rook or minor piece where it restricts the enemy king and supports the passer.
TACTICAL WARNING	Watch skewers, forks, rook sacrifices for the last pawn, promotion with check, and stalemate resources.
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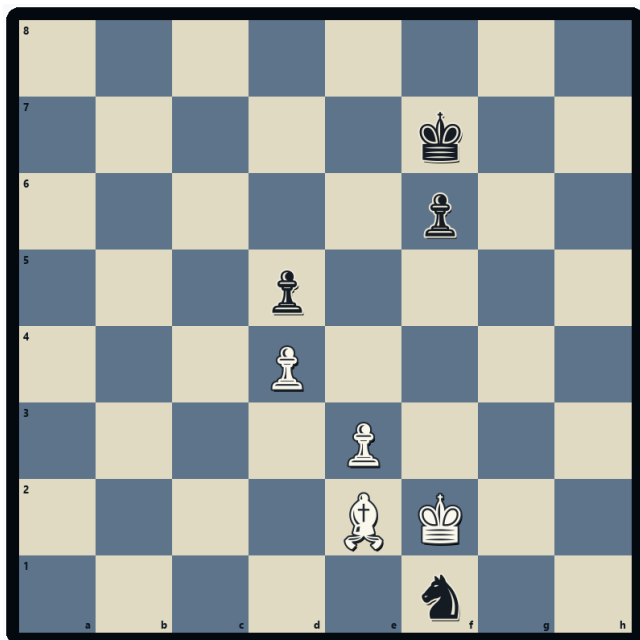
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Give checks from far enough away that the king cannot attack the rook with tempo.

07. Active Defense



REFERENCE LINE

White to move - minor-piece evaluation

MEMORY RULE

Attack pawns and create checking threats instead of waiting beside the king.

ROOK ENDGAMES

READ THE POSITION

Attack pawns and create checking threats instead of waiting beside the king.

PRIMARY PLAN

Identify the defender's best resource, map both king routes, and choose the move that preserves activity or the winning mechanism.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

The opponent seeks checks, king access, liquidation, a fortress, or a pawn race that changes the evaluation.

07. Decision Framework

Active Defense

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Calculate every forcing check, capture, pawn advance, and promotion tempo until the position becomes stable.
PIECE JOB	Place the king first, then position the rook or minor piece where it restricts the enemy king and supports the passer.
TACTICAL WARNING	Watch skewers, forks, rook sacrifices for the last pawn, promotion with check, and stalemate resources.
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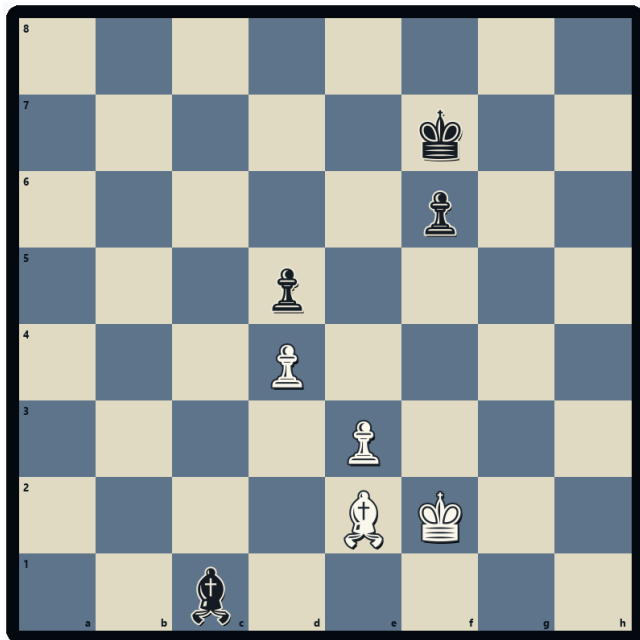
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Attack pawns and create checking threats instead of waiting beside the king.

08. Rook and Four Versus Rook and Three



ROOK ENDGAMES

READ THE POSITION

Create a passed pawn without allowing the defending rook to become active.

PRIMARY PLAN

Identify the defender's best resource, map both king routes, and choose the move that preserves activity or the winning mechanism.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

The opponent seeks checks, king access, liquidation, a fortress, or a pawn race that changes the evaluation.

REFERENCE LINE

White to move - fortress and passer study

MEMORY RULE

Create a passed pawn without allowing the defending rook to become active.

08. Decision Framework

Rook and Four Versus Rook and Three

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Calculate every forcing check, capture, pawn advance, and promotion tempo until the position becomes stable.
PIECE JOB	Place the king first, then position the rook or minor piece where it restricts the enemy king and supports the passer.
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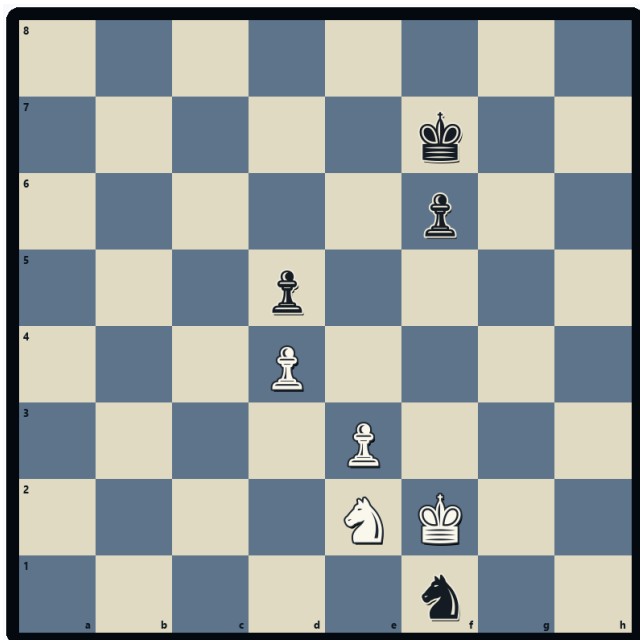
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Create a passed pawn without allowing the defending rook to become active.

09. The Short Side and Long Side



ROOK ENDGAMES

READ THE POSITION

Place the king on the short side and the rook on the long side for checking room.

PRIMARY PLAN

Identify the defender's best resource, map both king routes, and choose the move that preserves activity or the winning mechanism.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

The opponent seeks checks, king access, liquidation, a fortress, or a pawn race that changes the evaluation.

REFERENCE LINE

White to move - king and knight activity

MEMORY RULE

Place the king on the short side and the rook on the long side for checking room.

09. Decision Framework

The Short Side and Long Side

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Calculate every forcing check, capture, pawn advance, and promotion tempo until the position becomes stable.
PIECE JOB	Place the king first, then position the rook or minor piece where it restricts the enemy king and supports the passer.
TACTICAL WARNING	Watch skewers, forks, rook sacrifices for the last pawn, promotion with check, and stalemate resources.
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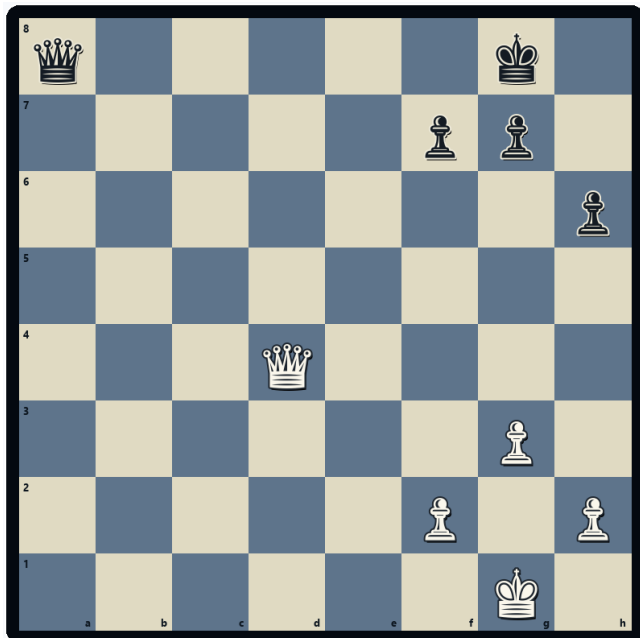
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Place the king on the short side and the rook on the long side for checking room.

10. Pawn Races With Rooks



ROOK ENDGAMES

READ THE POSITION

Calculate checks, rook sacrifices, and promotion tempi rather than counting pawn moves alone.

PRIMARY PLAN

Identify the defender's best resource, map both king routes, and choose the move that preserves activity or the winning mechanism.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

The opponent seeks checks, king access, liquidation, a fortress, or a pawn race that changes the evaluation.

REFERENCE LINE

White to move - checks and king shelter

MEMORY RULE

Calculate checks, rook sacrifices, and promotion tempi rather than counting pawn moves alone.

10. Decision Framework

Pawn Races With Rooks

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Calculate every forcing check, capture, pawn advance, and promotion tempo until the position becomes stable.
PIECE JOB	Place the king first, then position the rook or minor piece where it restricts the enemy king and supports the passer.
TACTICAL WARNING	Watch skewers, forks, rook sacrifices for the last pawn, promotion with check, and stalemate resources.
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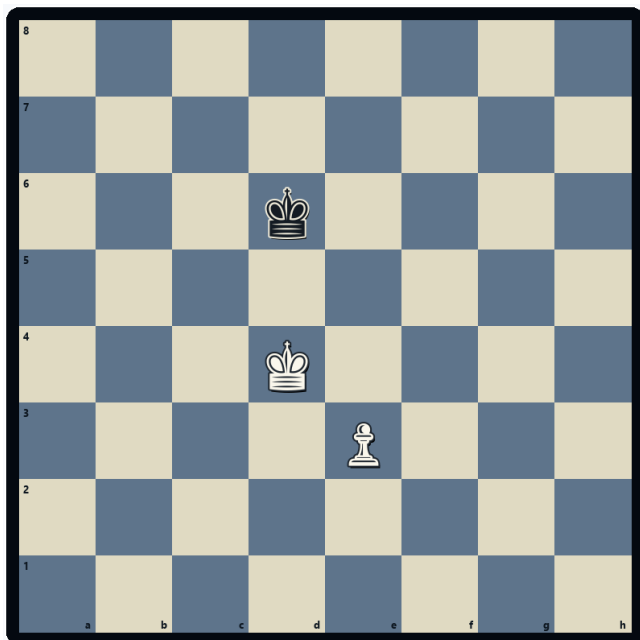
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Calculate checks, rook sacrifices, and promotion tempi rather than counting pawn moves alone.

11. Shouldering the King



ROOK ENDGAMES

READ THE POSITION

Use the king to deny entry squares while the rook attacks from the side.

PRIMARY PLAN

Identify the defender's best resource, map both king routes, and choose the move that preserves activity or the winning mechanism.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

The opponent seeks checks, king access, liquidation, a fortress, or a pawn race that changes the evaluation.

REFERENCE LINE

White to move - opposition study

MEMORY RULE

Use the king to deny entry squares while the rook attacks from the side.

11. Decision Framework

Shouldering the King

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Calculate every forcing check, capture, pawn advance, and promotion tempo until the position becomes stable.
PIECE JOB	Place the king first, then position the rook or minor piece where it restricts the enemy king and supports the passer.
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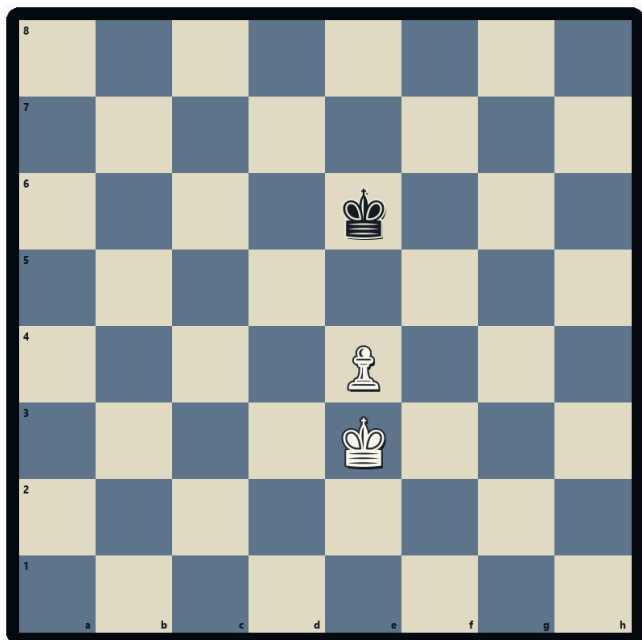
ACTIVE RECALL

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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Use the king to deny entry squares while the rook attacks from the side.

12. Rook Exchange Decisions



ROOK ENDGAMES

READ THE POSITION

Exchange rooks only when the pawn ending is demonstrably favorable.

PRIMARY PLAN

Identify the defender's best resource, map both king routes, and choose the move that preserves activity or the winning mechanism.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

The opponent seeks checks, king access, liquidation, a fortress, or a pawn race that changes the evaluation.

REFERENCE LINE

White to move - key-square study

MEMORY RULE

Exchange rooks only when the pawn ending is demonstrably favorable.

12. Decision Framework

Rook Exchange Decisions

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Calculate every forcing check, capture, pawn advance, and promotion tempo until the position becomes stable.
PIECE JOB	Place the king first, then position the rook or minor piece where it restricts the enemy king and supports the passer.
TACTICAL WARNING	Watch skewers, forks, rook sacrifices for the last pawn, promotion with check, and stalemate resources.
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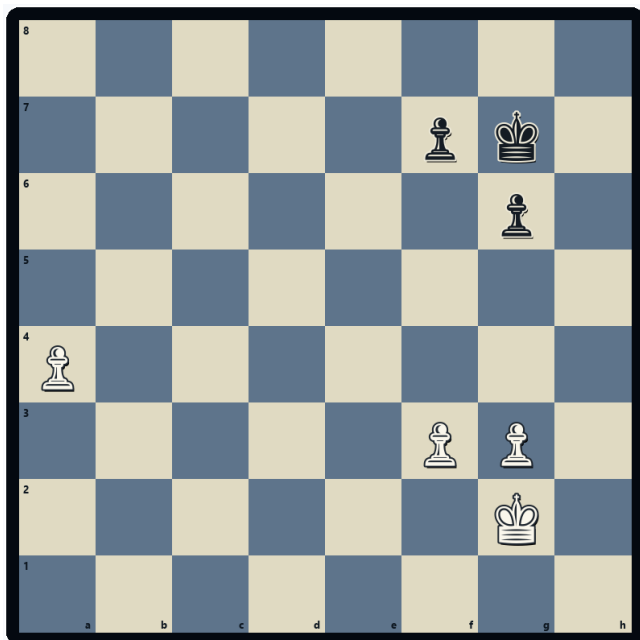
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1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Exchange rooks only when the pawn ending is demonstrably favorable.

13. Creating Shelter



ROOK ENDGAMES

READ THE POSITION

Use a pawn or the enemy pawn as cover from checks while advancing the king.

PRIMARY PLAN

Identify the defender's best resource, map both king routes, and choose the move that preserves activity or the winning mechanism.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

The opponent seeks checks, king access, liquidation, a fortress, or a pawn race that changes the evaluation.

REFERENCE LINE

White to move - create a diversion

MEMORY RULE

Use a pawn or the enemy pawn as cover from checks while advancing the king.

13. Decision Framework

Creating Shelter

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Calculate every forcing check, capture, pawn advance, and promotion tempo until the position becomes stable.
PIECE JOB	Place the king first, then position the rook or minor piece where it restricts the enemy king and supports the passer.
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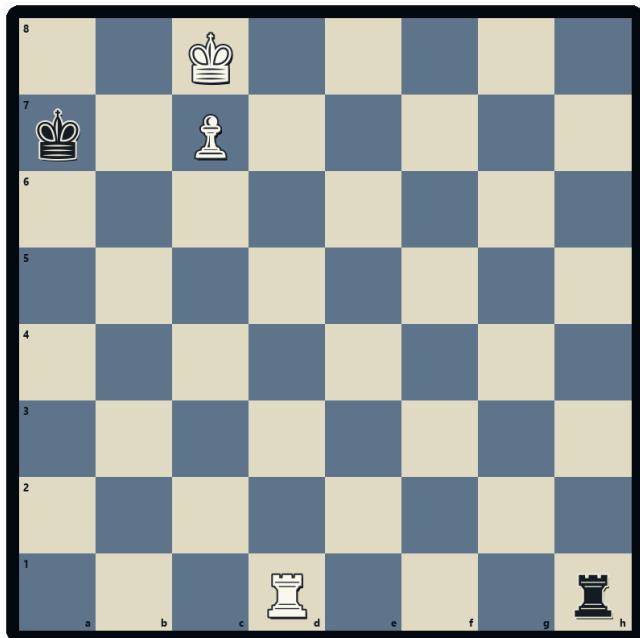
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Use a pawn or the enemy pawn as cover from checks while advancing the king.

14. Side Checks



REFERENCE LINE

White to move - Lucena-type position

MEMORY RULE

Side checks work when the attacking king lacks shelter and the rook has enough distance.

ROOK ENDGAMES

READ THE POSITION

Side checks work when the attacking king lacks shelter and the rook has enough distance.

PRIMARY PLAN

Identify the defender's best resource, map both king routes, and choose the move that preserves activity or the winning mechanism.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

The opponent seeks checks, king access, liquidation, a fortress, or a pawn race that changes the evaluation.

14. Decision Framework

Side Checks

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Calculate every forcing check, capture, pawn advance, and promotion tempo until the position becomes stable.
PIECE JOB	Place the king first, then position the rook or minor piece where it restricts the enemy king and supports the passer.
TACTICAL WARNING	Watch skewers, forks, rook sacrifices for the last pawn, promotion with check, and stalemate resources.
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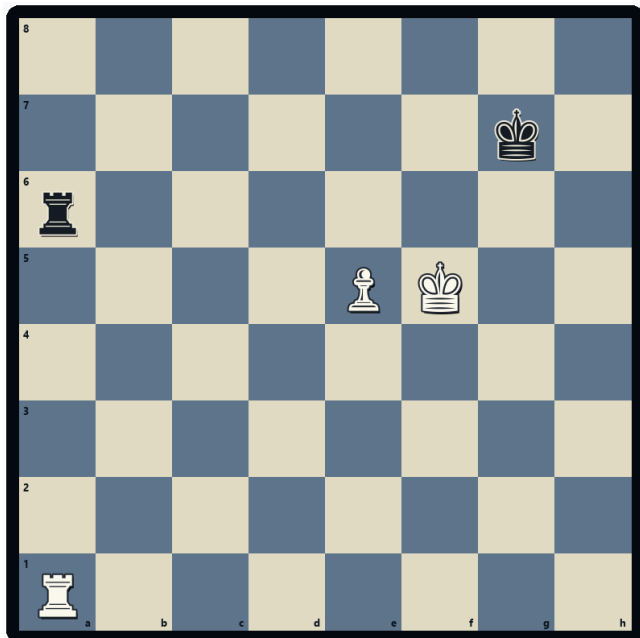
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Side checks work when the attacking king lacks shelter and the rook has enough distance.

15. Second-Rank Activity



ROOK ENDGAMES

READ THE POSITION

A rook on the second rank can attack pawns, cut the king, and create mating threats.

PRIMARY PLAN

Identify the defender's best resource, map both king routes, and choose the move that preserves activity or the winning mechanism.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

The opponent seeks checks, king access, liquidation, a fortress, or a pawn race that changes the evaluation.

REFERENCE LINE

Black to move - Philidor-type defense

MEMORY RULE

A rook on the second rank can attack pawns, cut the king, and create mating threats.

15. Decision Framework

Second-Rank Activity

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Calculate every forcing check, capture, pawn advance, and promotion tempo until the position becomes stable.
PIECE JOB	Place the king first, then position the rook or minor piece where it restricts the enemy king and supports the passer.
TACTICAL WARNING	Watch skewers, forks, rook sacrifices for the last pawn, promotion with check, and stalemate resources.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after proving the resulting pawn ending or theoretical position.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Reconstruct the position from memory and state the winning or drawing mechanism without moving pieces.
CLOCK RULE	Use known theoretical landmarks to save time, then calculate the concrete exception.

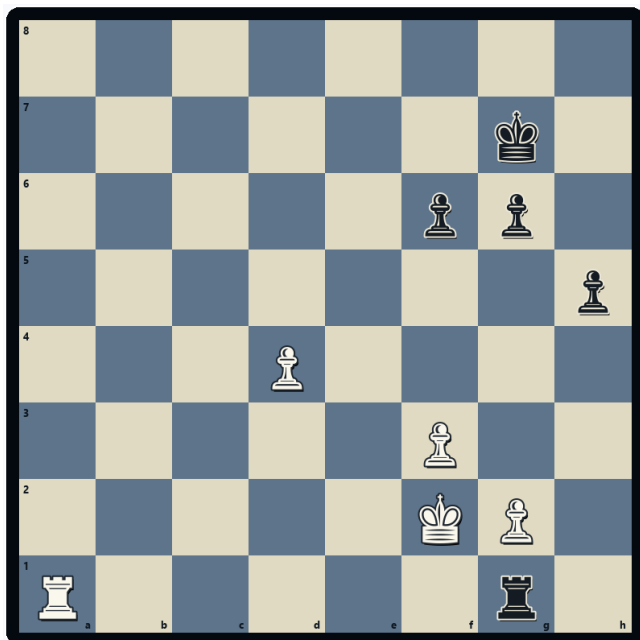
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: A rook on the second rank can attack pawns, cut the king, and create mating threats.

16. Defending the Seventh Rank



ROOK ENDGAMES

READ THE POSITION

Coordinate king and rook so penetration does not win pawns with tempo.

PRIMARY PLAN

Identify the defender's best resource, map both king routes, and choose the move that preserves activity or the winning mechanism.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

The opponent seeks checks, king access, liquidation, a fortress, or a pawn race that changes the evaluation.

REFERENCE LINE

White to move - activity over passivity

MEMORY RULE

Coordinate king and rook so penetration does not win pawns with tempo.

16. Decision Framework

Defending the Seventh Rank

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Calculate every forcing check, capture, pawn advance, and promotion tempo until the position becomes stable.
PIECE JOB	Place the king first, then position the rook or minor piece where it restricts the enemy king and supports the passer.
TACTICAL WARNING	Watch skewers, forks, rook sacrifices for the last pawn, promotion with check, and stalemate resources.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after proving the resulting pawn ending or theoretical position.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Reconstruct the position from memory and state the winning or drawing mechanism without moving pieces.
CLOCK RULE	Use known theoretical landmarks to save time, then calculate the concrete exception.

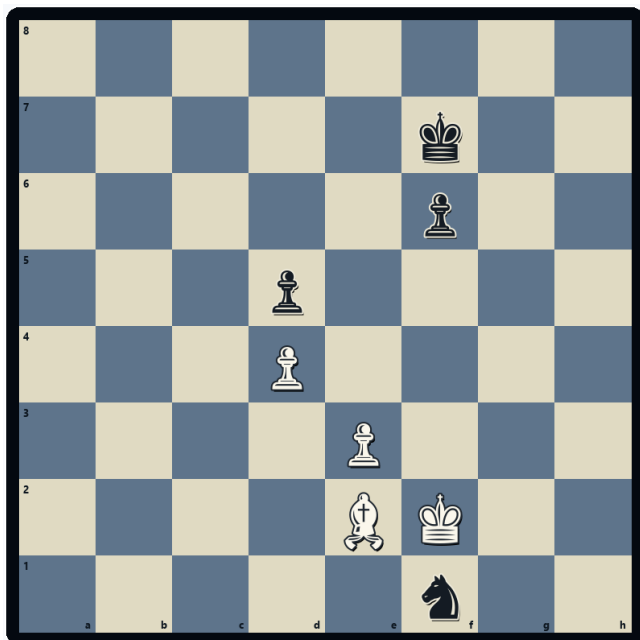
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Coordinate king and rook so penetration does not win pawns with tempo.

17. Two Connected Passers



ROOK ENDGAMES

READ THE POSITION

Place the rook behind the pawns and force them to advance into tactical vulnerability.

PRIMARY PLAN

Identify the defender's best resource, map both king routes, and choose the move that preserves activity or the winning mechanism.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

The opponent seeks checks, king access, liquidation, a fortress, or a pawn race that changes the evaluation.

REFERENCE LINE

White to move - minor-piece evaluation

MEMORY RULE

Place the rook behind the pawns and force them to advance into tactical vulnerability.

17. Decision Framework

Two Connected Passers

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Calculate every forcing check, capture, pawn advance, and promotion tempo until the position becomes stable.
PIECE JOB	Place the king first, then position the rook or minor piece where it restricts the enemy king and supports the passer.
TACTICAL WARNING	Watch skewers, forks, rook sacrifices for the last pawn, promotion with check, and stalemate resources.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after proving the resulting pawn ending or theoretical position.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Reconstruct the position from memory and state the winning or drawing mechanism without moving pieces.
CLOCK RULE	Use known theoretical landmarks to save time, then calculate the concrete exception.

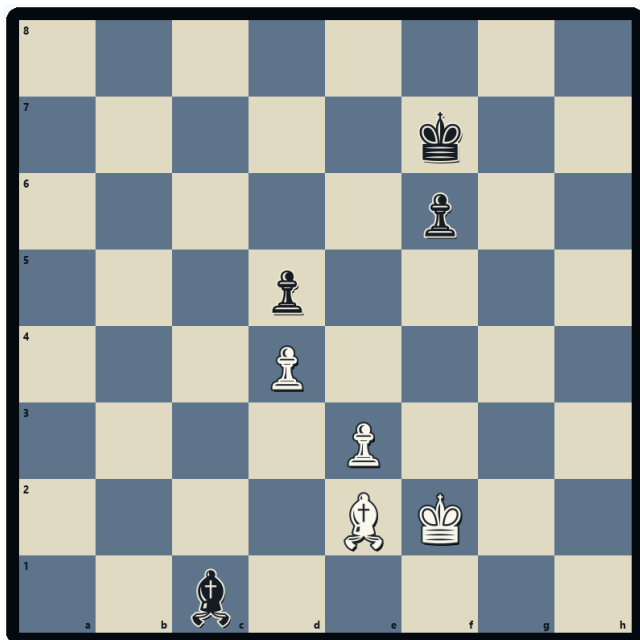
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Place the rook behind the pawns and force them to advance into tactical vulnerability.

18. One-Wing Rook Ending



ROOK ENDGAMES

READ THE POSITION

King activity and rook placement often matter more than an extra pawn on one wing.

PRIMARY PLAN

Identify the defender's best resource, map both king routes, and choose the move that preserves activity or the winning mechanism.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

The opponent seeks checks, king access, liquidation, a fortress, or a pawn race that changes the evaluation.

REFERENCE LINE

White to move - fortress and passer study

MEMORY RULE

King activity and rook placement often matter more than an extra pawn on one wing.

18. Decision Framework

One-Wing Rook Ending

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Calculate every forcing check, capture, pawn advance, and promotion tempo until the position becomes stable.
PIECE JOB	Place the king first, then position the rook or minor piece where it restricts the enemy king and supports the passer.
TACTICAL WARNING	Watch skewers, forks, rook sacrifices for the last pawn, promotion with check, and stalemate resources.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after proving the resulting pawn ending or theoretical position.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Reconstruct the position from memory and state the winning or drawing mechanism without moving pieces.
CLOCK RULE	Use known theoretical landmarks to save time, then calculate the concrete exception.

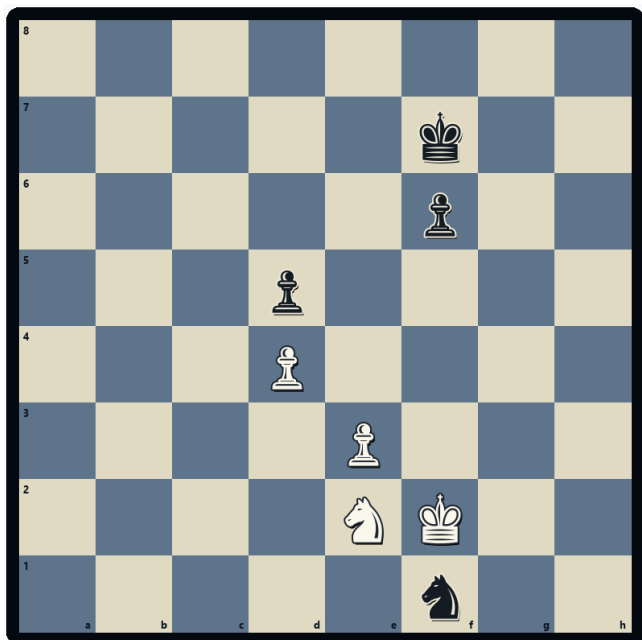
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: King activity and rook placement often matter more than an extra pawn on one wing.

19. Transition to Pawn Endings



ROOK ENDGAMES

READ THE POSITION

Calculate the pawn ending fully before trading the final rooks.

PRIMARY PLAN

Identify the defender's best resource, map both king routes, and choose the move that preserves activity or the winning mechanism.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

The opponent seeks checks, king access, liquidation, a fortress, or a pawn race that changes the evaluation.

REFERENCE LINE

White to move - king and knight activity

MEMORY RULE

Calculate the pawn ending fully before trading the final rooks.

19. Decision Framework

Transition to Pawn Endings

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Calculate every forcing check, capture, pawn advance, and promotion tempo until the position becomes stable.
PIECE JOB	Place the king first, then position the rook or minor piece where it restricts the enemy king and supports the passer.
TACTICAL WARNING	Watch skewers, forks, rook sacrifices for the last pawn, promotion with check, and stalemate resources.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after proving the resulting pawn ending or theoretical position.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Reconstruct the position from memory and state the winning or drawing mechanism without moving pieces.
CLOCK RULE	Use known theoretical landmarks to save time, then calculate the concrete exception.

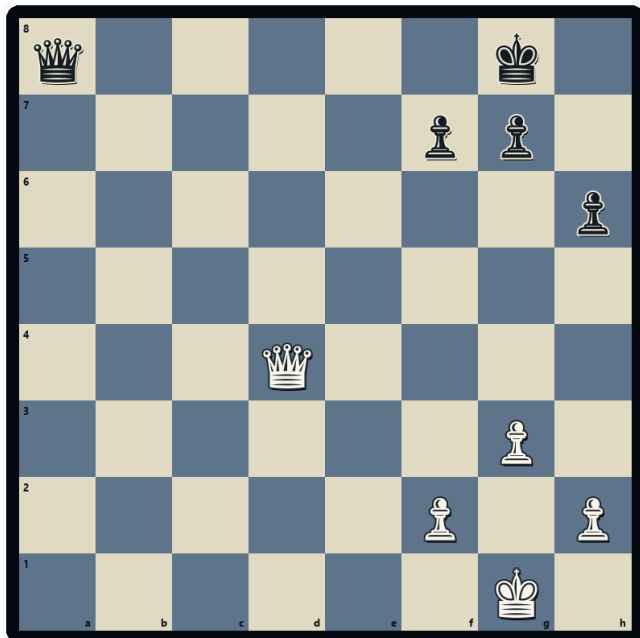
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Calculate the pawn ending fully before trading the final rooks.

20. Practical Rook-Endgame Routine



ROOK ENDGAMES

READ THE POSITION

Check activity, king cut-off, rook placement, passer, and checking distance in that order.

PRIMARY PLAN

Identify the defender's best resource, map both king routes, and choose the move that preserves activity or the winning mechanism.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

The opponent seeks checks, king access, liquidation, a fortress, or a pawn race that changes the evaluation.

REFERENCE LINE

White to move - checks and king shelter

MEMORY RULE

Check activity, king cut-off, rook placement, passer, and checking distance in that order.

20. Decision Framework

Practical Rook-Endgame Routine

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Calculate every forcing check, capture, pawn advance, and promotion tempo until the position becomes stable.
PIECE JOB	Place the king first, then position the rook or minor piece where it restricts the enemy king and supports the passer.
TACTICAL WARNING	Watch skewers, forks, rook sacrifices for the last pawn, promotion with check, and stalemate resources.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after proving the resulting pawn ending or theoretical position.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Reconstruct the position from memory and state the winning or drawing mechanism without moving pieces.
CLOCK RULE	Use known theoretical landmarks to save time, then calculate the concrete exception.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Check activity, king cut-off, rook placement, passer, and checking distance in that order.

Course Completion Test

Choose ten chapters at random. Rebuild each reference position, name both sides' plans, identify the critical break, and state the trade filter without reopening the chapter.

Score one point for the structure, one for your plan, one for counterplay, one for the break, and one for the memory rule. Forty out of fifty means the knowledge is usable; below forty means retrieval practice should continue.

FINAL PRINCIPLE

A course is complete when its ideas appear in your decisions, not when its pages have been read.